Week 5 · Checking input

Programming for Information Systems

Never trust input: check at the door

Class warm-up · Research 3 exchange

In groups of three, share the input check you researched.

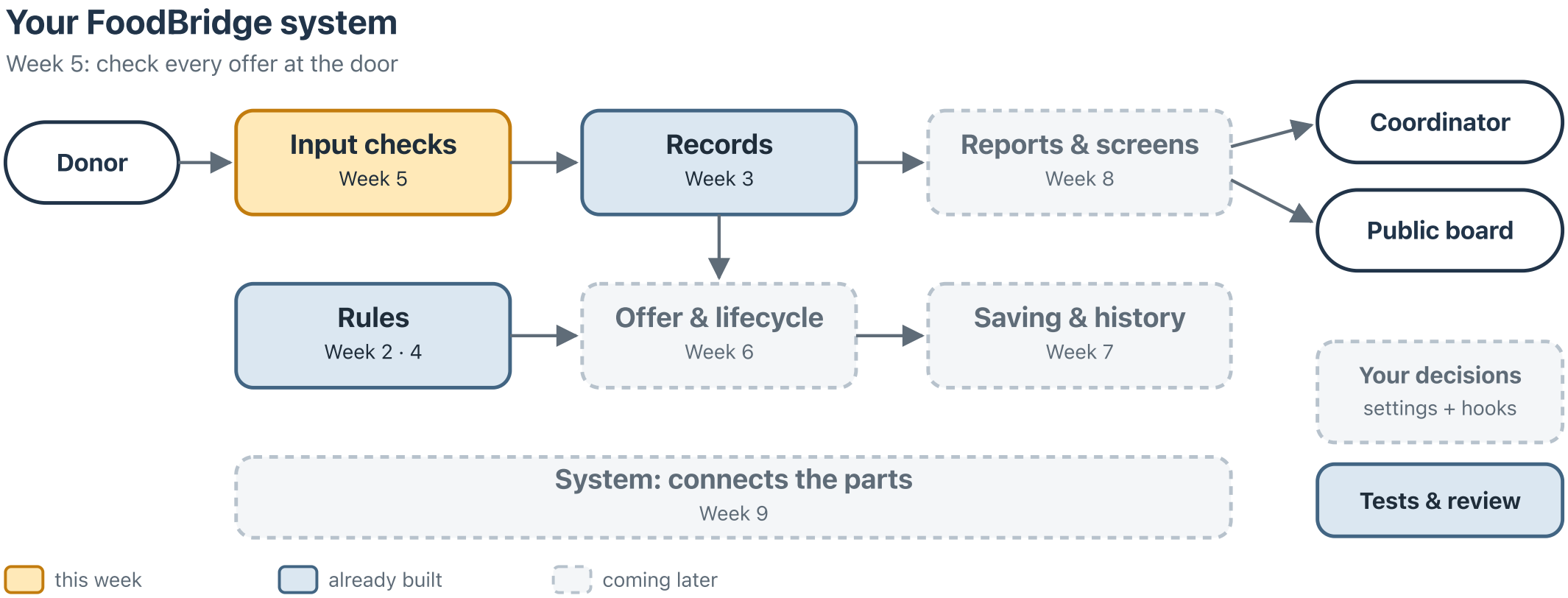
1. Which form did you study? What does it ask people to type?
2. Which check did you find? What **message** does a person see? Is it in plain words?
3. Name one input it **accepts but should refuse**, or **refuses but should accept**. Who is affected?

> 📝 Write down one idea from a classmate that you want to remember.

This week

Question	What should a system do when the input is wrong?
Python	`strip`, `lower`, `int()`, `try` / `except ValueError`, a list of errors, two return values
Principle 5	Never trust input
You build	`clean_offer(raw)` → `(offer, errors)`

Your system so far



The idea: check at the door

- At the airport, staff check your passport **before** you board.
- A system has doors too: a form, a file, a message.
- The door is the **cheapest** place to stop bad data.
- Once bad data is inside, it spreads into totals, reports and decisions.

> People are not careless on purpose. A good system **expects** wrong input.

Every value from a file is text

```
donor,contact,food,category,portions,hours_left
Sunrise Bakery,sunrise@example.org,Bread rolls,bread,30,5
Student Club Bake Sale,club@example.org,Cupcakes,snacks,many,6
Hotel Kitchen,hotel@example.org,Steamed rice,rice meals,1200,8
,,Mango slices,fruit,10,6
```

```
rows = bridge.validation.read_offers_csv("foodbridge_kit/data/offers.csv")
print(rows[0]["portions"], type(rows[0]["portions"]))   # 30 <class 'str'>
```

- A CSV file is only characters. It cannot say "this is a number".

Tidy text: `strip()` and `lower()`

```
typed = "  Dara "
print(typed == "Dara")                  # False
print(typed.strip() == "Dara")          # True
print(" Bread ".strip().lower())        # bread
print(" Bread " in CATEGORIES)          # False
print(" Bread ".strip().lower() in CATEGORIES)   # True
```

- A **method** is a function that belongs to a value: `text.strip()`.
- It returns **new** text; the original is unchanged.

`int()`: text to a whole number, or an error

```
print(int("30") + 4)      # 34
print(int(" 12 "))        # 12   (spaces at the ends are fine)
print(int("-3"))          # -3   a whole number, but sensible?
print(int("many"))        # ValueError
```

```
ValueError: invalid literal for int() with base 10: 'many'
```

- Converting is one check. The **range** is a second check.

`try` / `except ValueError`

```
quantity_text = "two"
try:
    quantity = int(quantity_text)
    print("Order for", quantity, "phones")
except ValueError:
    print("Please type the quantity as a number, for example 2.")
```

- Keep `try` **small**: only around the conversion.
- Catch **only** `ValueError`, the problem you expect.

Collect every problem

```
errors = []
if name.strip() == "":
    errors.append("name is required.")
try:
    age = int(age_text)
except ValueError:
    errors.append("age must be a whole number, for example 19.")
```

- Check **everything**, so the person can fix all problems at once.
- Plain words: **what** is wrong and **how** to fix it.

Return two values, unpack them

```
def check_age(age_text):
    try:
        age = int(age_text)
    except ValueError:
        return None, ["age must be a whole number, for example 19."]
    if age < 16:
        return None, ["volunteers must be 16 or older."]
    return age, []

age, errors = check_age("17")     # 17 []
```

Principle 5 · Never trust input

1. **Check at the door**, before anything is saved.
2. **Explain** every problem in plain words.
3. **Change nothing** when the input is bad.

> Trust is not about people. Honest people still type "many".

⚖️ Good or risky?

Version A (from an AI assistant)

```
def add_offer(raw):
    offer = {
        "donor": raw["donor"],
        "category": raw["category"],
        "portions": int(raw["portions"]),
    }
    saved_offers.append(offer)
    return "OK"
```

It crashed on "many". You said so.

Version B ("Fixed! It will never crash.")

```
def add_offer(raw):
    offer = {"donor": raw["donor"]}
    saved_offers.append(offer)  # save first
    try:
        offer["portions"] = int(raw["portions"])
    except:
        offer["portions"] = 0   # never crash
    if raw["category"] not in CATEGORIES:
        return "error"
    offer["category"] = raw["category"]
    return "OK"
```

What Version B did to the sample day

Row	What B saved	Who is harmed
Cupcakes, "many"	0 portions	the Student Club thinks it was accepted; nobody collects
Noodle soup, "soup"	half an offer, no category	the coordinator gets a broken record
Steamed rice, 1200	accepted	a team goes for food no partner can take
Mango slices, no donor	accepted	nobody knows where to collect

Silently wrong is worse than a clear refusal. A crash is noticed; a quiet 0 goes into the totals.

You build: `clean_offer(raw)`

Input	Return
a good row	`(offer, [])`: text stripped, category lowercase, numbers as `int`
a bad row	`(None, [every problem in plain words])`

- The **donor** reads the messages; the **coordinator** gets clean records.
- The limits are constants: `MIN_PORTIONS`, `MAX_PORTIONS`, `REJECT_IF_HOURS_LEFT_BELOW`, `CATEGORIES`, `REQUIRED_FIELDS`.

Four TODOs

```
def to_whole_number(text):
    ...                          # TODO 1: try int(text), except ValueError → None

def clean_offer(raw):
    donor = raw.get("donor", "")          # TODO 2: .strip() (and .lower())
    ...                                   # required fields: done for you
    if portions is None:
        errors.append("portions must be a whole number, for example 12.")
    # TODO 3: elif portions is outside MIN_PORTIONS..MAX_PORTIONS
    # TODO 4: category must be in CATEGORIES
```

- Most of the function is written for you. You fill in only the key lines.
- Test it on a messy row and a bad row **before** you run the check.

Check it, then plug it in

```
bridge.check("clean_offer", clean_offer, MY_SETTINGS)

my_system = bridge.System(MY_SETTINGS, hooks={"clean_offer": clean_offer})
my_system.run_day()           # 🚫 = a row YOUR door refused
```

- A door that refuses everything passes 6 of the 7 cases.
- That is why the **first** case is a good row with extra spaces.
- A refusal must change nothing: `records()` before == after.

🧭 Your decision · what does the door accept?

```
MIN_PORTIONS = 1
MAX_PORTIONS = 200
REJECT_IF_HOURS_LEFT_BELOW = 1
REQUIRED_FIELDS = ["donor", "food", "category", "portions", "hours_left"]
```

- **Portions:** is 1 portion worth a trip? Can any partner take 200?
- **Hours left:** with 1 hour left, can a volunteer still get there?
- **Required fields:** should `contact` be required?
  - **For:** the team can arrange the pickup and call about problems.
  - **Against:** the system holds more personal data, and must protect it.

> Decision log: my choice · an alternative · why · who is affected

This week's tasks

- ⭐ **Core:** P1–P4, the ⚖️ discussion, `clean_offer` with all ✅, plugged in, decision log.
- ⭐⭐ **Stretch:** surprising numbers (`int("9𝟟")` is 12!), one friendly message for the donor.
- 🔎 **Research 4 (5%):** how a real system keeps data and history: what is kept, which IDs, what happens on a correction, who needs the history. Share it in the Week 6 warm-up.

Next week · Objects and lifecycles

A clean offer still has a journey: **new** → **approved** → **picked up** → **delivered**. You will make sure it can only move the right way.